MILO
UI / UX DESIGN DEBRIEF

Visual identity · Island architecture · Interaction language · Screen-by-screen design specification

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Product: MILO — Windows-first floating desktop companion and productivity deck

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THE DESIGN PROMISE

> *A small, luminous presence at the top edge of the desktop that opens into a calm, capable personal workspace. MILO should feel crafted, warm and quietly futuristic: expressive enough to be memorable, restrained enough to live on screen all day.*

This document translates the product requirements into a coherent visual and interaction system. It is intended to guide product design, visual design, prototyping and implementation—not merely inspire them.

DESIGN NORTH STAR

Quiet magic, practical clarity. The magic lives in the island silhouette, lighting, avatar and transitions. The practicality lives in predictable controls, readable hierarchy, explicit states and low-friction workflows.

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01. Executive design direction

MILO is not a conventional productivity app with a floating shortcut. Its primary interface is a compact, edge-anchored island that can be ignored when the user is busy and entered instantly when the user needs it. The design must solve a difficult tension: it needs enough visual character to feel like a companion, but enough restraint to avoid becoming desktop clutter.

The island is the brand signature. The expanded deck is the work surface. The settings window is the configuration surface. These three contexts should share one design language while respecting their different jobs.

The visual concept

- Dark-first, not dark-only: a deep blue-black foundation with layered graphite/navy surfaces. Avoid pure #000 as the dominant canvas.
- Softly luminous: restrained cyan, periwinkle and mint light used as accents, focus cues and status signals—not as large neon panels.
- Glass-inspired, not glass-dependent: translucent-looking layers, fine edge highlights and controlled blur. Text and controls remain opaque enough to read in every wallpaper context.
- Organic geometry: a softened capsule/island silhouette, generous corner radii, nested cards and a few asymmetrical details that make MILO recognisable.
- Warm personality: the avatar gives the interface a little life, but it never becomes a mascot that blocks work or nags the user.
- Functional calm: clear labels, compact but comfortable controls, visible state, predictable navigation and restrained animation.

What MILO should feel like

Attribute	Desired impression	Avoid
Futuristic	Polished, dimensional, precise, subtly luminous	Cyberpunk overload, glowing grids everywhere
Cute	Warm avatar expressions, soft shapes, tiny moments of delight	Childish UI, oversized character art, baby-talk copy
Premium	Careful spacing, coherent typography, deliberate contrast	Gold trim, excessive gradients, faux-luxury gloss
Effortless	One-step access, glanceable information, low cognitive load	Hidden gestures, unclear icons, nested settings for common actions
Personal	Adaptive greeting, user-controlled accent and layout	Over-personalisation, unsolicited commentary, invasive data collection

Design decision: MILO should not mimic Apple's Dynamic Island literally. It may share the conceptual idea of an edge-attached, glanceable surface, but its silhouette, navigation, colour, animation, companion and desktop behaviours must establish a distinct product identity.

02. Product experience principles

Principle 1 — Be present without being in the way

Collapsed MILO should occupy a narrow, predictable strip at the top-centre edge. It must not cover important application controls, block window dragging, interfere with full-screen work or appear unpredictably. Its idle state should be visually quiet.

Principle 2 — Reveal detail progressively

The collapsed state shows only the island signature and a small amount of useful information. Hover or click expands it. The first expanded view prioritises the most-used information and quick actions. Deeper tools live in dedicated tabs or sections.

Principle 3 — Make state legible

A user should be able to tell whether Wi-Fi is on, a timer is running, a task is complete, a file is staged or media is paused without interpreting colour alone. Use icon, label, value and state together where space permits.

Principle 4 — Keep the companion optional

The avatar is an ambient character, not the interface's primary navigation. It appears in the expanded deck and selected moments. It can be reduced, hidden or set to a minimal presence in settings.

Principle 5 — Never surprise the user with files or system changes

Staged files remain where they are unless the user explicitly chooses a copy/move action. Toggles show the resulting state. System-level actions that require Windows permission explain why before opening the relevant OS prompt.

Principle 6 — Respect Windows conventions

MILO can have its own design identity while retaining familiar keyboard behaviour, focus states, accessible names, context menus and system permission flows. Microsoft recommends familiar controls and standard input behaviour because they reduce relearning and support accessibility. [1]

Principle 7 — Motion must explain

Every transition should communicate expansion, selection, progress, completion or state change. No animation exists only to decorate a frequently used control.

03. MILO’s physical form: the island and deck

Collapsed island

The collapsed island is a floating horizontal capsule anchored to the top-centre of the active display. It should look like a small, self-contained object sitting just below or attached to the top screen edge. It is not a full-width bar.

Property	Design specification
Position	Horizontally centred on the primary display by default; top edge offset configurable within a safe zone.
Width	Target 176–232 logical px depending on state and display scale; content may adapt between compact and expanded collapsed variants.
Height	Target 28–38 logical px, excluding shadow/glow.
Shape	Capsule with fully rounded ends; subtle asymmetry permitted in the avatar/brand mark, not in hit targets.
Surface	Deep translucent-looking navy/graphite fill with an opaque-enough base for legibility; very fine top/edge highlight.
Shadow	Soft downward ambient shadow; low opacity and broad blur. Avoid a hard floating black halo.
Brand cue	Small MILO glyph / avatar indicator plus one glanceable status such as time or active timer.
Interaction	Hover previews/expands after a short intent delay; click toggles open/closed. Keyboard shortcut opens it.
Dismissal	Click outside, Escape or re-click collapses, subject to unsaved edits and active drag operations.

Collapsed state hierarchy

- Primary: MILO signature mark or tiny avatar silhouette.
- Secondary: time or current activity indicator, depending on user's chosen compact layout.
- Tertiary: tiny status dots for active timer, staged files or media only when enabled and useful.
- Never cram Wi-Fi, battery, volume, Bluetooth and every status into the collapsed capsule. The island is a doorway, not a miniature taskbar.

Expanded island / deck

The expanded deck grows downward from the same top-centre anchor. It should feel like the capsule unfolding into a small floating control centre. The upper edge remains visually connected to the collapsed island; avoid a gap that makes it feel like a separate window.

Property	Design specification
Width	Recommended default 620–760 logical px; minimum 520 px; maximum 820 px. Allow compact mode.
Height	Recommended 520–680 logical px, capped to usable work area; internal content scrolls.
Anchor	Top-centred with a safe margin from display edges and reserved system UI.

Property	Design specification
Silhouette	Large rounded outer shell (24–30 px radius) with nested sections (14–20 px radius).
Navigation	Compact left rail or top segmented navigation depending on width; desktop default should favour a slim left rail.
Avatar	Visible in expanded header or greeting zone; never overlays controls or text.
Scroll	Content pane scrolls independently; header and navigation remain stable.
Dismiss	Click outside or Escape closes; if a file is being dragged, remain open until drop/cancel.

The expanded panel should visually inherit the island's top capsule. Use a shared top highlight, consistent surface tint and a gentle expansion animation so the user perceives one object changing form.

Visual anatomy

- Top lip: the expanded continuation of the island, carrying the MILO mark, compact greeting/time and global close/collapse control.
- Navigation rail: overview, system, productivity, files, music and settings. Current selection is unmistakable.
- Content stage: the main area containing cards, controls and lists.
- Companion nook: a small, bounded area for avatar presence, contextual expression or short status. It may collapse at narrower widths.
- Bottom utility strip: optional quick status for active timer, media or staged file count. Do not turn it into a second taskbar.

04. Layout system and responsive behaviour

Grid and spacing

Use a 4 px base spacing unit. Most spacing should land on multiples of 4 or 8. The deck should feel spacious even when information-dense; density is achieved through hierarchy and progressive disclosure, not by shrinking everything.

Token	Value	Use
space-1	4 px	Icon/text gap, micro alignment
space-2	8 px	Tight control groups, chip padding
space-3	12 px	Compact card padding, list row gaps
space-4	16 px	Default card padding and content gutters
space-5	20 px	Section separation
space-6	24 px	Major layout gaps
space-8	32 px	Large section spacing
space-10	40 px	Page-level breathing room

Width breakpoints

Deck width	Behaviour
520–599 px	Compact mode: navigation becomes horizontal/scrollable; avatar nook hidden; cards stack one column.
600–719 px	Standard compact: narrow rail, single-column content, compact metadata.
720–820 px	Comfortable: full left rail, two-column card layouts where appropriate, avatar nook can appear.
Above 820 px	Do not expand the floating deck indefinitely. Keep a designed max width; optionally open a dedicated full settings window for deep configuration.

Display and DPI

- Scale all measurements in logical pixels and test Windows display scaling at 100%, 125%, 150%, 175% and 200%.
- Reposition the island per monitor when the active display changes; do not assume all monitors share the same DPI.
- Keep the deck within the working area and avoid overlapping taskbar-reserved regions where possible.
- At low vertical resolution, reduce decorative header height first; preserve control sizes and scroll access.
- At high text scaling, let cards grow vertically. Never clip task names, file names or control labels.

Scroll behaviour

Use one obvious vertical scroll region per page. Avoid nested scroll areas unless the interaction requires them, such as a lyrics pane within a music page. Scrollbars should be subtle at rest and become more visible on hover/focus. The content should not jump when the scrollbar appears.

05. Colour system and tokens

MILO's colour system is a deep, cool foundation with a small set of luminous accents. The recommended default is a dark theme because it supports the floating-island metaphor and the product's premium, atmospheric character. A light theme should still be designed as a first-class theme, not a colour inversion.

Core dark palette

Token	Hex	Role
milo-ink-950	#080D18	Deepest app canvas / outer shadow base
milo-ink-900	#0B1220	Primary shell background
milo-surface-850	#111A2A	Main cards and content surfaces
milo-surface-800	#151F30	Raised cards / selected surface
milo-surface-750	#1B2940	Hover / active raised surface
milo-line	#2A3950	Borders, dividers, separators
milo-text-primary	#F1F5FC	Primary text
milo-text-secondary	#B4C1D3	Secondary text
milo-text-muted	#8292A9	Tertiary labels / disabled-adjacent copy
milo-cyan	#63D9E8	Primary accent / focus / active highlight
milo-violet	#9B8CFF	Secondary accent / creative / avatar glow
milo-mint	#80E0C0	Positive / completed / energy-saving
milo-amber	#F4C77A	Caution / attention / pending
milo-rose	#FF7D91	Error / destructive / urgent

Accent behaviour

- Use cyan for primary selection, keyboard focus, active toggles and primary action emphasis.
- Use violet sparingly for secondary brand expression, music/creative areas and avatar atmosphere.
- Use mint for success, completed tasks, power-saving active states and positive feedback.
- Use amber for reminders due soon, low battery, incomplete setup and caution.
- Use rose for destructive actions, failed operations and urgent error states.
- Do not colour every card. Most cards should remain neutral; colour is a signal, not wallpaper.

Gradient signature

Primary brand gradient: cyan → soft periwinkle. Use as a narrow highlight, active indicator, avatar aura, subtle island edge glow or progress fill. It should not be the default fill for all buttons or cards.

Suggested gradient: linear 110° from #63D9E8 through #8BB7F4 to #9B8CFF. Keep saturation controlled and avoid placing small text directly on a gradient.

Semantic colour rules

Meaning	Colour	Required secondary cue
Success	Mint	Check icon or explicit 'Completed' label
Warning	Amber	Warning icon and plain-language explanation
Error	Rose	Error icon and recovery action
Information	Cyan	Info icon or label
Disabled	Muted neutral	Disabled semantics and no hover affordance

Light theme

The light theme should use a cool mist canvas (#F2F5FA), white/near-white cards (#FFFFFF/#F8FAFD), slate text (#182234), quiet blue-grey borders (#D9E1EC) and the same accent hues adjusted for sufficient contrast. Keep the island more opaque in light mode so it remains visually anchored against bright wallpapers.

Accessibility baseline: normal text should meet at least 4.5:1 contrast; large text at least 3:1. Do not rely on accent colour alone to convey state. Fluent typography guidance also calls out these contrast thresholds. [2]

06. Typography and iconography

Typeface direction

Primary recommendation: Segoe UI Variable / Segoe UI as the Windows-native foundation. It is familiar, highly legible and aligns with current Fluent guidance. Use a restrained display treatment for time and key metrics rather than introducing a decorative typeface for the entire interface. [3]

Role	Typeface / weight	Size / line height	Usage
Display time	Segoe UI Variable, Semibold	32–40 / 40–48	Clock and large timer readout
Page title	Segoe UI Variable, Semibold	20–24 / 28–32	Main tab heading
Section title	Segoe UI Variable, Semibold	14–16 / 20–22	Card and group titles
Body	Segoe UI Variable, Regular	13–14 / 19–20	Descriptions and list content
Body strong	Segoe UI Variable, Semibold	13–14 / 19–20	Task titles, active values
Caption	Segoe UI Variable, Regular	11–12 / 15–16	Metadata, timestamps, helper copy
Micro label	Segoe UI Variable, Semibold	10–11 / 14	Short uppercase-independent labels

Typography rules

- Use sentence case for labels and headings. Avoid all-caps UI labels.
- Use tabular numerals for clocks, timers, dates and numeric values to prevent layout jitter.
- Do not use thin weights for small text or low-contrast labels.
- Use a maximum of three weights in one component.
- Keep text left-aligned by default; centre only short status messages, empty states or compact clock compositions.
- Use truncation with a tooltip or accessible full value for long filenames and task titles; do not silently cut off important meaning.

Iconography

Use a consistent outline icon family with rounded joins and a 1.75–2 px stroke at 24 px. Lucide-style icons are a good starting point, provided the chosen set is audited for consistency. Use filled or duotone icons only for selected states or the avatar's own expressive art.

- 24 px for primary controls; 20 px for compact actions; 16 px for inline metadata.
- Use familiar metaphors: bell for reminders, check-square for tasks, timer/clock for timers, folder for files, music note for media, sliders for settings.
- Keep icon hit targets at least 40×40 logical px where feasible; compact icon-only controls still need generous invisible hit areas.
- Every icon-only button needs an accessible name and a tooltip on pointer hover.
- Do not invent cryptic abstract glyphs for core Windows controls.

07. Materials, depth, borders and lighting

Material philosophy

MILO should evoke glass, but its interface must not depend on live background transparency to remain readable. Use a stable dark surface as the base, then add subtle translucent-looking layers, controlled blur and fine edge highlights. Windows Fluent guidance distinguishes long-lived Mica surfaces from transient Acrylic surfaces; that distinction is useful conceptually even if the implementation uses custom web-rendered surfaces. [1][4]

Layer	Appearance	Purpose
L0 — ambient	Transparent window region with restrained shadow	Makes the island appear detached from desktop
L1 — shell	Deep navy/graphite, high opacity	Reliable primary contrast surface
L2 — cards	Slightly lighter solid surface	Groups content and controls
L3 — popovers	Acrylic-like blur/tint or solid fallback	Menus and transient pickers
L4 — focus	Cyan outline / soft glow	Shows keyboard focus and active control

Surface treatment

- Outer shell: 1 px border in low-opacity blue-grey; optional inner top highlight.
- Cards: subtle surface contrast, 1 px border, no heavy shadow by default.
- Raised popover: slightly stronger shadow and a thin border; visually above the deck.
- Primary button: cyan-tinted surface or gradient accent, clear foreground contrast.
- Secondary button: neutral raised surface with border.
- Destructive button: neutral at rest; rose emphasis on hover/confirmation context.

Lighting

The lighting should feel like a soft studio reflection, not an RGB gaming keyboard. Place the brightest glow behind the island's active mark or along a short edge segment. Keep the rest of the shell calm. The avatar may have a gentle aura that responds to state, but it should never illuminate the entire deck.

Transparency fallback

If Windows effects are unavailable, disabled, too expensive or visually harmful, MILO should fall back to its designed solid surface with no loss of hierarchy. Tauri exposes window transparency/effects and always-on-top configuration, but platform-specific constraints need testing on Windows rather than assuming every CSS transparency effect maps to native window transparency. [5][6]

08. Component design language

Component	Design specification
Primary button	Filled cyan/blue accent, 10–12 px radius, 40–44 px height, clear verb label. One primary action per card or dialog.
Secondary button	Neutral surface, fine border, same geometry as primary. Used for cancel, edit, secondary navigation.
Tertiary / ghost button	No visible fill at rest; subtle hover surface. Used for low-priority actions and toolbar utilities.
Icon button	40×40 hit target, 20–24 px icon, tooltip, visible focus ring. Never icon-only without accessible name.
Toggle	Pill switch with clear on/off track and thumb. Label remains visible; show state text where the outcome is consequential.
Slider	Thin track with larger thumb; value label or live value where useful. Keyboard-operable and not colour-only.
Segmented control	2–4 options for mutually exclusive modes; selected option has clear filled surface and text contrast.
Chip	Compact rounded pill for filters, categories, due-date labels and staged-file status. Avoid using chips as the only navigation.
Card	14–18 px radius, 16 px padding, quiet border. Use cards to group related functions, not to wrap every single line.
List row	Minimum 48 px high for primary rows; hover background, selected indicator, right-side contextual actions.
Text field	Dark raised surface, 1 px border, clear placeholder and label, strong focus ring. Validation text sits below field.
Dropdown / menu	Anchored popover with 8–12 px radius, clear selected item, keyboard navigation and escape dismissal.
Tooltip	Short, delayed, pointer-only hint; never required to understand essential functionality.
Progress bar	Thin 4–6 px track with rounded ends. Show numeric/time context when progress is meaningful.
Toast	Small transient status near deck edge; includes concise result and optional undo/action.
Dialog	Use only for destructive confirmation, permission explanation or multi-step decisions. Keep narrow and focused.

Interaction states

State	Visual treatment
Rest	Neutral surface and normal text.
Hover	Small surface lift/lighten; no layout shift.
Pressed	Slightly darker/pressed surface; immediate feedback.
Focused	Distinct 2 px cyan/contrast outline, offset where needed.
Selected	Persistent selection fill/indicator and accessible selected state.
Disabled	Muted text and surface, no hover or pointer affordance; explain why if not obvious.
Loading	Inline progress/spinner plus stable label; prevent duplicate action.
Error	Rose icon/text plus recovery instruction; preserve user input.

A component's state must be communicated through more than hue. Combine shape, icon, label, position or state text where the consequence matters.

09. Motion, transitions and sound

Motion character

MILO's motion should feel like a soft mechanical object unfolding with a hint of personality. Use spring-like easing sparingly, with quick response and no overshoot that makes the deck feel bouncy or toy-like.

Motion	Recommended duration	Behaviour
Hover intent	120–180 ms delay	Avoid opening on incidental pointer pass.
Island expand	220–320 ms	Width/height and opacity move together; origin stays attached to top edge.
Island collapse	180–240 ms	Content fades slightly before shell contracts.
Tab switch	140–200 ms	Crossfade or short horizontal shift; preserve spatial continuity.
Popover	120–180 ms	Scale/opacity from anchor point.
Toast in/out	180–220 ms	Short slide/fade; no repeated bouncing.
Avatar idle	Slow, occasional	Subtle blink/breathing; no continuous distracting animation.
Task completion	160–240 ms	Checkmark and gentle row-state transition; do not make completed row disappear instantly.

Motion rules

- Use a reduced-motion preference. Replace spatial movement with fades or instant state changes.
- Never delay a system control action for animation. The visual transition follows the state change.
- Do not animate every card when the deck opens; animate the shell first, then reveal content with a restrained stagger only if it improves comprehension.
- Do not use perpetual pulsing on battery, Wi-Fi, timer or avatar indicators.
- Respect full-screen apps and presentation mode; disable or minimise ambient motion when the user has chosen focus behaviour.

Sound

Sound is off by default for UI feedback. If added, keep it optional, quiet and limited to user-configured events such as timer completion. No sound on hover, tab switching or ordinary toggles. Windows notification sounds should not be duplicated by MILO.

10. Navigation and information architecture

The expanded deck uses a compact navigation rail on standard desktop width. Each destination has a recognisable icon and a short label. The current destination receives a slim cyan indicator and raised neutral background. On narrow widths, the rail converts to a horizontal tab strip.

Primary destination	Purpose	Default landing content
Overview	At-a-glance personal dashboard	Time/date, quick status, next reminder, active timer, now playing
System	Device and connectivity controls	Power/battery, Wi-Fi/network, Bluetooth, volume, brightness, energy saver
Productivity	Personal planning hub	Tasks, reminders, timers and alarms overview
Files	Temporary file holding bay	Drop area, staged files, drag-out workflow
Music	Media and lyrics	Now playing, controls, queue, lyrics when available
Settings	Configuration and privacy	Appearance, behaviour, shortcuts, integrations, data and about

Navigation rules

- Do not create a separate primary tab for every small productivity function. Keep Tasks, Reminders, Timers and Alarms as sub-navigation within Productivity.
- Keep global actions reachable regardless of tab: close/collapse, search/command, quick add and help where appropriate.
- Remember the last visited primary tab for the next opening, but offer a setting to always open Overview.
- Switching tabs should not reset scroll position or discard drafts.
- Show active background work as a subtle count or status, not as an always-on notification badge.

11. Expanded shell and global chrome

Header

The header is a shallow horizontal region directly beneath the island lip. Left: MILO glyph and a short context label (for example, 'Good evening' or the current page name). Centre or right: compact clock/status if it is not already in the collapsed island. Far right: search/command, collapse and settings shortcuts only if not duplicated by navigation.

Navigation rail

The rail should be about 64–76 px wide in icon-and-label mode, with 8–12 px vertical spacing between destinations. Active item receives a quiet raised background and 2–3 px accent bar or dot. Use a tooltip when the rail is icon-only.

Content area

Main content begins with a page title and optional subtitle/action. Content cards align to a consistent 12–16 px gap. Keep the first screenful useful without scrolling. Use a single content column for task lists and settings; use two columns for dashboard cards when the width allows.

Companion placement

Avatar should sit near the header or in a bounded companion nook in Overview. On deep task pages, it can shrink to a small corner presence or disappear. The avatar must never occupy more than roughly 12–15% of the visible content area in standard mode.

Global quick add

A plus action opens a compact command menu: Add task, Add reminder, Start timer, Set alarm, Add files. It should use verbs, keyboard shortcuts and clear destinations. Do not create an ambiguous universal '+' that opens a blank form.

12. Overview tab — the home dashboard

Overview is MILO's welcome mat. It should answer four questions immediately: What time is it? What needs my attention next? What is currently active? What can I control quickly?

Recommended composition

Region	Content	Layout
Greeting strip	Time-aware greeting, date, avatar expression	One shallow header row; time may be large but not dominant
Clock card	Large digital time, weekday/date	Primary card; tabular numerals; optional 12/24h format
Quick status	Battery/power, network, Bluetooth, volume, brightness summary	Compact grid of 4–5 controls; opens System tab for detail
Up next	Next reminder and next alarm	One or two stacked rows with time and action
Focus / tasks	Top 2–3 due or pinned tasks	Short list with completion affordance
Now playing	Track title, artist, artwork thumbnail, play/pause	Compact horizontal card; visible only when media session exists or user pins it
Active timer	Countdown, progress and stop/pause	Appears only while active; persistent but not alarmingly bright

Visual hierarchy

The clock and next actionable item are the two strongest content elements. Quick status is secondary. Music and active timer are conditional modules. Avoid a dashboard made of equal-sized cards: it makes everything compete.

Avatar behaviour

The avatar may greet the user with one short, non-intrusive line after opening, but should not repeat greetings on every tab switch. It can react to a completed task or timer completion with a small expression. No speech bubbles by default.

Empty overview

When no tasks, reminders or media exist, keep the page balanced with useful setup prompts: 'Add your first task', 'Create a reminder' and 'Connect a media source'. Avoid a blank empty dashboard or a large illustration that pushes core information down.

13. System tab — quick device controls

System is a compact control centre. The layout should prioritise reliable, clearly labelled toggles and sliders over decorative system cards.

Top status band

Show battery percentage and power source, current network connection, Bluetooth state and active energy saver state. Status labels must remain visible at all times; do not make users infer state from icon tint.

Control groups

Group	UI pattern	Interaction details
Power & battery	Wide status card + energy saver toggle	Battery %, charging state, estimated time only if OS provides reliable value. Energy saver toggle includes state label.
Wi-Fi / network	Connection card + network picker entry	Show connected network name only where privacy setting permits; open Windows settings if native network selection is required.
Bluetooth	Toggle + connected device summary	Show 'On/Off' and device name; pair/manage opens native settings where appropriate.
Volume	Horizontal slider + mute button	Live percentage/value, keyboard arrows, mute state; do not jump volume on focus.
Brightness	Horizontal slider	Show only if controllable through supported hardware/API; otherwise provide a clearly labelled Windows Settings shortcut.
Quick actions	Small action tiles	Airplane mode or other controls only if safely supported and permissioned.

Important UX constraint

MILO must distinguish between a control it can change directly and a shortcut that opens Windows Settings. Never draw a switch that looks live if the action is actually delegated to Windows.

Permission / unsupported states

If brightness control is unavailable on a desktop monitor, show 'Brightness is managed by your display' and a relevant help link rather than a dead slider. If a system capability is unsupported, explain the limitation and offer the native Windows route.

14. Productivity hub — structure and overview

Productivity is the home for Tasks, Reminders, Timers and Alarms. It should feel like a calm personal organiser, not a project-management suite. Keep creation fast and detail editing optional.

Productivity landing page

- Top title: 'Productivity' with a concise subtitle such as 'Your next steps, in one place'.
- Four compact category tabs or segmented sub-navigation: Tasks, Reminders, Timers, Alarms.
- Overview strip with due today, upcoming reminders and active timer count.
- Quick-add button with explicit action choices.
- Content area that remembers last-used sub-tab.

Interaction model

Creation forms should start small. Ask for the essential information first, then reveal advanced recurrence, notification and categorisation options when requested. Use inline editing for titles and completion state. Keep destructive actions behind a context menu or confirmation when data loss is possible.

List rhythm

Rows are 48–56 px high with a 16 px leading icon/check control, primary label, metadata below or to the right, and a trailing action menu. Due status uses text and icon as well as colour.

15. Tasks and to-do lists

Page composition

- Header with 'Tasks', count of open tasks and an 'Add task' primary button.
- Filter row: Today, Upcoming, All, Completed. A compact list or dropdown for lists/categories.
- Task list grouped by date or list name, with collapsible groups.
- Optional pinned tasks section at top; keep it to a few items.
- Completed tasks remain available under Completed and can be hidden by preference.

Task row

Element	Specification
Completion control	20 px check circle/square; large 40 px hit area; clear checked state.
Task title	14 px body strong; wraps to 2 lines before truncating.
Metadata	Due date/time, list/category, recurrence icon if relevant.
Priority	Optional low/normal/high label or subtle marker; never a full-width saturated stripe.
Trailing actions	Edit, duplicate, delete via contextual menu.
Completed	Text muted but readable, checkmark visible; do not immediately remove row.

Add task

Inline add row with text field and optional date chip. Press Enter creates the task; a small expansion control opens date, reminder, list and notes. If the title is empty, the create action is disabled. Preserve typed text if the user changes tabs accidentally.

Task details

A compact side sheet or in-deck detail view contains title, notes, due date, reminder, list, recurrence and created/updated metadata. Avoid a full-screen modal for simple task edits.

16. Reminders

Reminders are time-based prompts, not merely tasks with a date. The design should make the trigger time, recurrence and notification behaviour explicit.

Reminder list

- Group by Today, Tomorrow, Later and Past due.
- Each row shows reminder title, trigger time/date and recurrence if present.
- Past-due reminders are visually distinct but not alarm-red unless genuinely urgent.
- Provide quick snooze and mark-done actions from the row or notification.

Create reminder flow

Step	UI	Details
1. What	Title field	Required; clear example placeholder such as 'Call the dentist'.
2. When	Date/time picker	Default sensible time; never silently assume a time zone or recurrence.
3. Repeat	Optional recurrence control	None, daily, weekdays, weekly, custom.
4. Notify	Notification behaviour	Desktop notification; sound optional; show preview of what will appear.
5. Save	Primary action	Return to list with the new reminder highlighted briefly.

Notification presentation

A reminder notification should be concise and actionable: title, time/context, Snooze and Done. Do not force the user to open MILO for common actions. The deck can show a subtle reminder badge while a reminder is due.

17. Timers and alarms

Timers

Timers should be visually immediate and satisfying. The primary timer view has a large tabular countdown, a clear start/pause/resume button and a secondary reset action. Presets (5, 10, 15, 25, 45 minutes) may be shown as chips, but custom duration must remain available.

- Active timer card persists on Overview and collapsed island as a small indicator, if the user enables it.
- Show remaining time and a subtle progress ring or arc; never rely on the ring alone.
- Allow multiple timers only if the underlying product scope supports them; otherwise make the single-active-timer rule explicit.
- Completion state offers Dismiss, Restart and optionally Start another preset.
- Timer sound is opt-in and configurable.

Alarms

Alarms use a clock-face or time-picker input, not a timer-style duration input. List alarms with time, label, repeat schedule and on/off toggle. Disabled alarms remain visible but subdued. An alarm edit view exposes repeat days, sound, snooze duration and label.

Alarm notification

The alarm surface must have a clear stop/dismiss action and a separate snooze action. Use a larger, more persistent notification than a reminder. Provide a quiet-hours / sound policy and explain Windows notification limitations during onboarding or settings.

18. Files — temporary holding bay / dropzone

This is a signature workflow. It must feel like a temporary staging surface—not a file manager, not cloud storage and not a hidden relocation tool.

Page composition

- Header: 'Files' with a clear explanation: 'Hold files here while you switch apps'.
- Large drop target at the top with dashed/soft luminous outline and folder-plus icon.
- Staged files appear as compact rows/cards beneath the drop target.
- Each row shows filename, extension/type icon, size and original location/source where available.
- Actions: Preview/open, Remove from MILO, Copy path, Clear bay. Avoid a generic 'Delete' action.
- Optional grouping by recent batch or date; default is newest staged items first.

Drop target states

State	Visual behaviour
Idle	Neutral dashed border; 'Drop files here' with helper text.
Drag over	Border and icon glow cyan; helper becomes 'Release to add to your holding bay'.
Accepted	Brief checkmark and 'Added to holding bay'; list updates.
Unsupported	Amber or rose icon with exact reason; preserve existing staged files.
Empty	Friendly compact explanation plus Browse files action.
Full / limit reached	Clear message about capacity and options; never silently discard older items.

Staged file row

Use a file-type glyph, filename, extension chip if useful, size and source path in secondary text. Long filenames wrap or truncate with a tooltip. The trailing remove action removes only the staging reference; it must not delete the original file.

Drag-out workflow

The key interaction is dragging a staged file from MILO into another application. The row should provide a clear drag handle or make the row itself draggable. During drag, MILO stays open and the file's original path remains valid. On successful drop, the file remains in its original location unless the destination app itself performs a copy/upload. Do not imply that MILO can guarantee upload completion in another app.

Safety and trust copy

Use explicit wording: 'Removing from MILO only clears it from this holding bay. Your original file stays where it is.' If a user chooses an actual copy/move operation in a future version, make the operation and destination explicit before execution.

19. Music — now playing and media controls

Music landing page

Music should feel more immersive than the other tabs, but still use the same shell and card language. The page can use a subtle artwork-derived tint behind the player, with a dark overlay to maintain text contrast.

Now-playing composition

Element	Specification
Artwork	Square cover image, 88–120 px; rounded 12–16 px corners. If unavailable, show a designed neutral music glyph.
Track metadata	Title in semibold, artist below, album/streaming source in muted caption.
Transport	Previous, play/pause, next. Play/pause is the primary 44 px circular control.
Progress	Scrubbable timeline with elapsed and total time where available.
Volume	Optional inline control; avoid duplicating System volume if it changes master output.
Queue	Optional expandable queue/list if source provides it.
Lyrics entry	Visible action only when lyrics are available or a provider supports lookup.

Media states

- No media session: explain 'Nothing is playing' and offer supported media source guidance.
- Paused: play icon and 'Paused' status; do not show an active animated visualiser.
- Playing: subtle progress update and small motion in artwork accent; no constant pulsing.
- Unavailable metadata: keep controls usable and label missing metadata gracefully.
- Multiple media sessions: show the active session and allow explicit switching if supported.

Source boundaries

MILO should not imply universal control of every music service. The UI must distinguish system media session support from service-specific integrations. Unsupported controls should be disabled with an explanation, not rendered as functional-looking decoration.

20. Lyrics experience

Lyrics are a secondary experience inside Music, not a separate top-level destination. The page should support a clean reading mode with a clear indication of whether lyrics are synchronised, plain text, unavailable or supplied by a licensed provider.

Layout

- Track header at top with compact artwork, title and artist.
- Lyrics pane uses a centred column with a comfortable line length.
- Current synchronised line receives a gentle brighter text treatment and subtle accent marker.
- Previous and next lines remain visible at lower contrast but must still be readable.
- Scrolling manually should pause auto-follow until the user taps 'Follow current line' or playback changes substantially.
- Font-size controls and a high-contrast lyrics mode are available.

Availability and rights

When lyrics are unavailable, show a neutral explanation and return focus to the player. Never fabricate lyrics or scrape and display copyrighted lyrics without an appropriate rights basis. The interface should clearly identify when synchronisation is unavailable.

21. Avatar / companion system

The avatar is MILO's emotional signature. It should feel like a small, friendly digital companion—cute, expressive and polished—without becoming a character that demands attention.

Visual design

- Silhouette: simple, memorable and readable at small sizes. Prefer a compact creature/mascot form with a strong outline and two or three defining features.
- Material: soft matte body with restrained luminous accents; avoid excessive specular gloss.
- Palette: neutral body with cyan/periwinkle highlights; mint/amber/rose accents only for clear states.
- Face: minimal eyes and mouth; expressions should be legible at 24–48 px.
- Motion: blink, gentle breathing, tiny tilt or short celebratory bounce. No constant idle choreography.
- Scale: 32–56 px in standard deck; optional larger expression moment on onboarding or completion.

Expression library

State	Expression	When
Neutral	Calm open eyes, slight smile	Default idle
Curious	Small head tilt / attentive eyes	User opens MILO or enters a new section
Focused	Concentrated eyes, minimal movement	Timer/focus session active if that feature exists
Happy	Bright eyes, small smile	Task completion or successful file staging
Sleepy	Soft half-lidded eyes	Late-hour optional cosmetic state; never infer health or fatigue
Concerned	Gentle serious expression	Error or warning; never guilt-inducing
Celebratory	Short, restrained bounce	Milestone or timer completion; user can disable

Behaviour rules

- Never make the avatar speak unsolicited paragraphs.
- Never use guilt, disappointment or shame when tasks are overdue.
- Do not imply that the avatar is monitoring the user or watching activity.
- Do not use the avatar to convey critical system status without text/icon redundancy.
- Offer settings for avatar visibility, animation intensity and greeting frequency.
- Reduced motion and hide-avatar preferences must be respected globally.

22. Search, command and quick actions

A command/search surface makes MILO feel fast. It should open from a visible search icon and a configurable keyboard shortcut. The command surface can search tasks, reminders, files in the holding bay and available actions.

Command palette

- Search field receives focus immediately.
- Recent actions appear when the field is empty.
- Results grouped by Actions, Tasks, Reminders and Staged files.
- Keyboard arrows move selection; Enter activates; Escape closes.
- Use plain-language actions: 'Start a 10 minute timer', 'Add a task', 'Open Files'.
- Do not expose arbitrary file-system search unless separately designed and permissioned.

Quick action menu

The global plus button opens a small menu with named destinations. It should not open a giant modal. Each item uses icon, verb and optional keyboard shortcut. Selecting an item opens the smallest relevant creation form.

23. Notifications and overlays

Toast notifications

Toasts are for non-urgent confirmations: file staged, task saved, setting changed. Place them inside or just below the deck edge, not in the centre of the screen. Keep them visible long enough to read and provide Undo when appropriate.

Reminder and alarm overlays

Reminder notifications are compact and actionable. Alarm notifications are more persistent and include stop/snooze. Respect Windows notification settings and avoid duplicating the same message in multiple surfaces.

Popover rules

- Anchor popovers to the triggering control and keep them within the display work area.
- Dismiss on outside click and Escape unless a drag or unsaved action is in progress.
- Do not cover the control that opened them.
- Use a stable opaque surface if blur would reduce legibility.
- Menus must be keyboard navigable and announce selected/disabled states.

Modal rules

Use a modal only when the user must make a consequential choice or when a workflow cannot fit in a popover. Keep modal width around 360–480 px. One clear primary action, one secondary action, no competing footer actions.

24. Settings and personalisation

Settings should be a calm, well-organised page with a left sub-navigation or grouped sections. Avoid a long unstructured list of switches.

Section	Controls and content
Appearance	Dark/light/system theme, accent colour, transparency intensity, corner/compact mode, density, avatar visibility.
Island behaviour	Hover-to-open, click-to-open, auto-collapse delay, top offset, display selection, show on all supported displays.
Overview	Choose modules, order of cards, clock format, date format, default landing tab.
Notifications	Reminder delivery, alarm sound, snooze duration, quiet hours, preview behaviour.
Shortcuts	Open/collapse, quick add, command palette, start timer, navigation shortcuts.
System controls	Capability availability, native settings handoff, permission explanation.
Files	Holding bay capacity, clear-on-exit preference, staged-file retention, privacy explanation.
Music	Preferred media session, artwork, lyrics provider/availability, player layout.
Avatar	Show/hide, animation intensity, greeting frequency, expression effects.
Privacy & data	Local data location, export, clear data, diagnostics opt-in, update channel.
About	Version, update status, licenses, support, release notes.

Settings interaction

Use immediate apply for reversible appearance preferences and explicit Save for multi-field forms. Destructive data actions require a clear explanation and confirmation. Provide Reset to defaults at section level and a separate global reset.

25. Onboarding and first-run experience

Onboarding should be short, visual and skippable. The first launch should demonstrate the island's central interaction rather than bury the user in a feature tour.

Step	Experience
1. Welcome	A quiet introduction: 'A little more room for your day.' Show the island silhouette.
2. Position	Let user choose top-centre placement and test hover/click behaviour.
3. Essential preferences	Theme, 12/24-hour clock, avatar visibility. Defaults are sensible.
4. Windows permissions	Explain each permission only when needed; user can skip and enable later.
5. First action	Offer one optional action: add a task, stage a file or start a timer.
6. Finish	Deck opens to Overview; a small guide tip explains how to collapse and reopen.

Onboarding principles

- Do not require account creation for core functionality.
- Do not request all system permissions up front.
- Use real interactive demonstrations, not a carousel of screenshots.
- Allow skip and revisit from Settings.
- Do not show multiple tooltips at once.
- Persist progress safely if onboarding is interrupted.

26. Empty, loading, error and permission states

Scenario	Recommended treatment
Empty tasks	Small icon, one sentence and Add task action. No shame or productivity pressure.
No reminders	Explain that nothing is scheduled; provide Create reminder.
No media session	Neutral player state and short explanation.
Lyrics unavailable	'Lyrics aren't available for this track' plus return-to-player action.
No staged files	Clear dropzone and Browse files action.
Loading system status	Skeleton or small spinner with 'Checking device status'; no fake default value.
Permission denied	Explain which capability is unavailable and offer Windows Settings path where possible.
Unsupported device	Explain the specific limitation; avoid dead control.
Network unavailable	Keep local features usable; show offline status only where relevant.
Save failure	Preserve entered content, show reason and retry.
Notification blocked	Explain that Windows notifications are disabled and link to relevant settings.
Update available	Non-blocking banner; allow later, show version and restart implications.

Error writing

Error copy should describe what happened, what is safe, and what the user can do next. Avoid vague messages such as 'Something went wrong' without a recovery path. Never clear a form because a save failed.

27. Accessibility and inclusive interaction

- Keyboard access: all functions reachable without pointer. Logical tab order, visible focus, Escape dismissal and standard arrow-key behaviour in menus and lists.
- Screen readers: accurate accessible names, roles, values and state announcements for toggles, sliders, task completion, timers and notifications.
- Contrast: at least 4.5:1 for normal text and 3:1 for large text; test muted labels and text on tinted surfaces.
- Colour independence: status always includes text, icon or shape in addition to hue.
- Text scaling: test up to 200% and allow cards and rows to grow.
- Motion: respect reduced-motion preferences and provide static alternatives for avatar and transition effects.
- Hit targets: aim for 40–44 px interaction areas even when icons are smaller.
- Focus visibility: focus ring must remain visible against both card and shell backgrounds.
- High contrast: verify Windows contrast themes and ensure important boundaries remain visible.
- Input diversity: pointer, keyboard, touch where supported, pen and assistive technology.

Microsoft's Windows app guidance explicitly recommends keyboard access, visible focus indicators, accessible names/roles/states, contrast-theme testing and text scaling. These are release requirements, not optional polish. [1]

28. Desktop behaviour and Windows integration

Window and taskbar behaviour

- MILO should not behave like a normal full-size app window when operating as the island. It should remain a controlled floating surface with predictable focus and dismissal.
- Define how it appears in Alt+Tab, taskbar, virtual desktops and multi-monitor setups. Prefer not to create confusing duplicate entries.
- Provide a tray entry for Open MILO, Settings, Pause/Resume background activity and Quit.
- Full-screen apps and games need a configurable hide/pause behaviour.
- Respect display changes, DPI changes, sleep/resume and explorer restarts.

Focus and activation

Hover can preview the deck, but keyboard and click must remain reliable. The deck should not steal focus simply because the pointer passes over it. When a text field is activated, focus moves predictably and the keyboard shortcut can be used to return to the island.

Multi-monitor

Default to the primary display, but allow selection of a specific display. If the chosen display disconnects, move to the primary display and explain the fallback. Avoid duplicate islands unless the user explicitly enables per-display instances.

Implementation caution

Tauri supports custom window configuration, always-on-top, transparency-related options and window effects. However, the actual Windows composition, input regions, shadow and focus behaviour must be validated in a real packaged build. Design mocks alone cannot prove that a transparent floating window behaves correctly. [5][6]

29. Content design and microcopy

Voice

MILO's voice is warm, concise and quietly confident. It should sound like a helpful utility with a little personality—not a chatbot trying to be your best friend.

Context	Preferred copy	Avoid
Welcome	'A little more room for your day.'	'Your life is about to change!'
Task added	'Task added'	'Look at you being productive!'
Task overdue	'This task is overdue'	'You forgot again!'
File staged	'Added to your holding bay'	'Uploaded successfully' (unless actually uploaded)
Permission	'Windows needs permission to control brightness'	'Permission required' with no explanation
No lyrics	'Lyrics aren't available for this track'	Invented or misleading lyric content
Timer complete	'Timer finished'	Overly dramatic praise or alarm copy

Writing rules

- Lead with the state or action, not a joke.
- Use direct verbs: Add, Save, Start, Pause, Resume, Remove, Clear, Open.
- Use 'Remove from MILO' when the original file remains untouched.
- Use 'Clear holding bay' for removing staged references in bulk.
- Keep helper text to one or two short sentences.
- Never claim an external upload, sync or system change succeeded unless MILO can verify it.

30. Design tokens and handoff checklist

Suggested token namespace

Token group	Examples
Color	color.canvas, color.surface.1, color.surface.2, color.text.primary, color.text.secondary, color.accent.primary, color.status.warning
Spacing	space.1 through space.10; 4 px base
Radius	radius.sm=8, radius.md=12, radius.lg=16, radius.xl=24, radius.pill=999
Typography	type.display, type.title, type.section, type.body, type.caption
Elevation	elevation.shell, elevation.card, elevation.popover, elevation.toast
Motion	motion.fast, motion.standard, motion.expand, motion.reduce
Sizing	control.height.sm=32, md=40, lg=44; icon.size.sm=16, md=20, lg=24
Opacity	opacity.disabled, opacity.scrim, opacity.border.subtle

Design handoff package

- Component library with rest, hover, pressed, focus, selected, disabled, loading and error states.
- Desktop shell mockups for collapsed, hover-preview, expanded, compact and full settings states.
- Page designs for Overview, System, Productivity, Tasks, Reminders, Timers, Alarms, Files, Music, Lyrics and Settings.
- Avatar expression sheet and motion clips.
- Dark and light theme tokens.
- Accessibility annotations, keyboard map and screen-reader labels.
- Empty, loading, offline, unsupported and permission-denied states.
- Responsive behaviour at each width and Windows display scale.
- Motion specification with duration, easing, trigger and reduced-motion fallback.
- Asset exports, icon source, naming conventions and token file.

31. QA scenarios and acceptance criteria

Area	Acceptance criteria
Collapsed island	Visible, recognisable, unobtrusive; correct position; no flicker; keyboard accessible.
Expansion	Anchored to island; smooth and fast; no content jump; closes predictably.
Navigation	Every tab reachable; selection visible; scroll and drafts preserved appropriately.
System controls	Accurate live state; unsupported capability handled honestly; no fake controls.
Tasks/reminders	Create, edit, complete, snooze and delete flows clear; input preserved on error.
Timers/alarms	State remains accurate through collapse, sleep/resume and notification actions.
Files	Drag-in and drag-out tested with common Windows apps; remove from bay never deletes source.
Music	Correct active media session; clear unsupported states; controls reflect actual system state.
Lyrics	Availability state accurate; no fabricated or unlicensed content.
Avatar	Optional, restrained, reduced-motion compliant and never blocks a task.
Accessibility	Keyboard-only, screen reader, contrast, scaling and reduced motion pass.
Desktop	Multi-monitor, DPI, full-screen, Alt+Tab, taskbar and sleep/resume tested.
Performance	No perceptible lag on open/close; no constant expensive blur or animation while idle.

Critical usability tests

- Can a first-time user discover how to open and close the island without instruction?
- Can a user stage a file, switch apps and drag it out without fearing the original will be moved or deleted?
- Can a user tell whether a system toggle actually changed the device state?
- Can a keyboard-only user create a reminder and dismiss the deck?
- Can a user with reduced motion use every feature comfortably?
- Can a user understand why brightness or lyrics are unavailable?

32. Open design decisions

The following decisions should be validated in prototype testing. They are not blockers to starting the visual system, but they should be settled before implementation hardens.

Decision	Recommended default	Reason
Navigation rail vs top tabs	Left rail at standard width; top strip only in compact mode	Better scalability across six destinations.
Avatar location	Header / bounded companion nook	Visible without competing with content.
Collapsed island contents	MILO mark + time or one active-state cue	Keeps the island clean and recognisable.
Hover expansion delay	150 ms intent delay, adjustable	Avoid accidental opening while crossing screen.
Auto-collapse	Off while interacting; short delay after pointer leaves only if user enables	Prevents accidental dismissal.
Theme default	Dark	Strongest expression of the product's signature identity.
Light theme	Supported at launch if feasible; otherwise follow soon after	Avoid locking out user preference.
Per-monitor islands	One island on selected display by default	Avoid clutter and duplicate surfaces.
File retention	Persist staged references until user clears them; disclose behaviour	Predictable and trust-preserving.
Avatar animation	Low intensity default	Personality without distraction.

Prototype priorities

- Prototype A: collapsed-to-expanded transition and edge anchoring.
- Prototype B: Overview information hierarchy and navigation.
- Prototype C: Files dropzone and drag-out workflow.
- Prototype D: System controls with honest unsupported states.
- Prototype E: Avatar scale, placement and motion intensity.

33. Reference sources

The following sources inform the Windows interaction, material, typography and implementation recommendations in this debrief. MILO should borrow the principles that improve usability while maintaining its own distinctive identity.

[1] Microsoft Learn — Windows app best practices
https://learn.microsoft.com/en-in/windows/apps/get-started/best-practices
Windows UX expectations, common controls, materials, accessibility, keyboard and scaling.

[2] Microsoft Fluent 2 — Color
https://fluent2.microsoft.design/color/
Neutral/shared/brand palette roles, semantic colour and interaction-state usage.

[3] Microsoft Fluent 2 — Typography
https://fluent2.microsoft.design/typography
Segoe UI type direction, type ramps, casing and contrast guidance.

[4] Microsoft Fluent 2 — Material
https://fluent2.microsoft.design/material
Solid, Acrylic, Mica and Smoke material roles.

[5] Tauri v2 — Window Customization
https://v2.tauri.app/learn/window-customization/
Custom titlebars, transparency and window appearance considerations.

[6] Tauri v2 — Configuration reference
https://v2.tauri.app/reference/config/
Window configuration including always-on-top, transparency-related effects and dimensions.

[7] Microsoft Learn — Design Windows apps
https://learn.microsoft.com/en-gb/windows/apps/design/
Current Windows design guidance for layout, navigation, colour, materials, motion and accessibility.

How to use this document

Treat the visual tokens, component rules and page descriptions as the design source of truth. Where implementation constraints require a change, preserve the underlying user experience: the island remains unobtrusive, the deck remains legible, system state remains honest, file staging remains safe, and the avatar remains optional.

MILO should feel like it belongs on the desktop—and like it was designed with care down to the smallest interaction.